

ASSABIAN RITES

By Jonathan Drake

THENNLA (Thennalt); THEYASO (Jekkarene); SAMANESH (Tarsenian); SOBRYNIA (Korantine); ANKETESI (Sheng); PLAHUS (Archipelagan); BONAYA FARANG (Rasputan); YALU SAMA (Jande); THUMUL-THUKA'A (Orcish)

ZO-RA-DE-MA

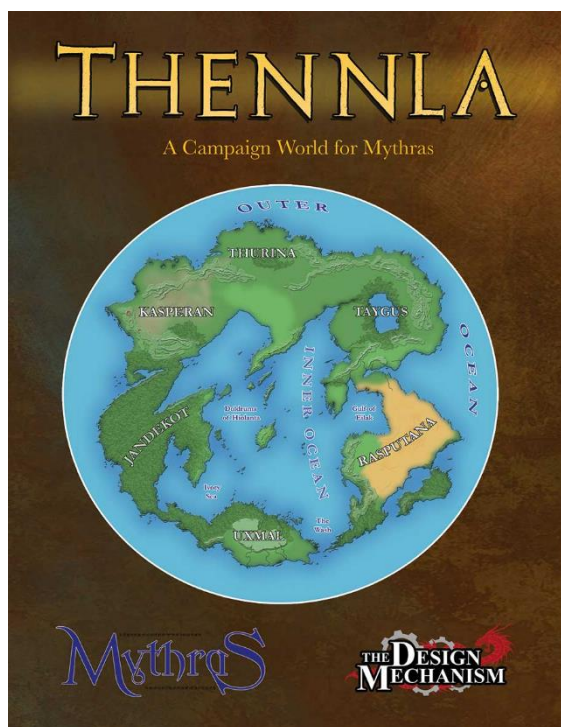
Fire – Air – Earth – Water (Djesmiri)

ZORADEMA-SYA (The World and all life in it)

Thennla is just one name for the world in which you can find the Shores of Korantia, the Taskan Empire, the Sultanates of Djesmirket and the Sunlit Lands of the Essenzerai. It's the name given by the Thennalts, a matrix of connected and related but also diverse cultures who are found over much of the continent of Taygus. It is named for their earth goddess, Theyna, or her consort, Thenn, a character who has little mythological significance other than being husband to his wife. Korantines often use Thennla interchangeably with a word of their own, Sobrynia, which describes all of creation 'beneath heaven', even though for them Thennla more properly describes the earth beneath one's feet. The Sheng word Anketesi denotes whatever is not sky nor beneath the waters' surface, strictly the surface that one can bend down and touch. For some peoples the world itself is a god or goddess, usually one that is distant and inaccessible compared to the gods and spirits that are normally worshipped. Bonaya Farang is first the Mother of the Continents and also Mother of the Gods, the being whom the Gods themselves worship, but too great for mere mortals to grasp. For the Orcs of Kasperan the true spirit of the earth, the thing that gives it life, is what lies beneath - the vital forces and vast energies locked beneath the skin of the world that we witness as eruptions of molten lava.

The World

One day I found I had to give a name to a fantasy world I'd been working on and building for many years without ever feeling the need. How could I publish a setting book and tell the readers what to call the world they would be reading about? Under pressure to come up with something I genuinely felt all creativity elude me. The killer cool name people would remember, that would somehow convey a setting vibe just in a few syllables, and wouldn't sound just like another really good setting name. Nope, nothing. So I went about it methodically – picked out some mythological names of entities known in the setting who would have a claim to give their name to the world. And then look for an iteration of that which didn't sound like a lost province of Glorantha that went missing down the back of Greg Stafford's sofa. And so:



I have to say – I have never liked the result. Not aesthetically in print, nor the basic English language logic of how it is written and how it sounds. Two 'N's? Hmmm. So I comfort myself now that the methodology remains sound, the name remains a logical product of the setting,

and of course by that measure the world in habited by the Taskans, Korantines, Jekkarenes and so many others will have a myriad of names. Maybe one day one of those will catch on...

One Setting and Many Settings

It all began in an early version of what is now Korantia, but before long player-characters went travelling to distant lands, opening up new regions on the map. When there was a hiatus to play other games or for another GM to take their turn in the chair, I would use that to reboot or change of direction next time it was my turn to run a game. This often resulted in relocating the next campaign to a different region of the world with new characters rather than creating an entirely new setting. The new region could be quite different in tone and feel from the last, different culture types and especially different types of magic and religion to get to grips with – something the rulesets that we played with, from Runequest through to Mythras, made possible. It always seemed to me that, just like in the real world, there does not need to be a single or holistic theme that encompasses all the setting. But nonetheless connective tissue between regions and plotlines would be written in from the outset and eventually they would co-exist in the same world in a more dynamic way. Of course things that interest the author show up in the world and while those changed over time, there's some commonality at work, and that's reflected in some of the core setting themes.

Setting Themes

There are some of the key themes that have emerged in developing the setting. These weren't part of any grand plan of world-building that was there at the start. But even so, you can see consistent patterns have

emerged from the sub-conscious to become part of the setting's essential fabric.

Magic is a Technology

If magic works, and can be made to work by those who learn its ways, then it will become incorporated into the fabric of the economy, used for commercial game, public good and personal advantage. In this respect it is no different to any other technology – it becomes dangerous or benevolent according to who is wielding it, for whose benefit and for what purpose. There is no reason that a fantasy milieu in which magic works cannot ask the same questions as a science fiction setting, and the story of the Iron Simulacrum and the immortal Emperor Zygas Taga draws on tropes of science fiction in which artificial means are deployed to prolong life or to preserve consciousness.

Magical orders, religious cults, governments and culture-groups will attempt to monopolise specific magical spells, rituals and so on, but it is impossible to monopolise all or even a substantial part of the vast array of magical practices, powers and potential to be found in the world. Instead there may be cultural taboo, legal restriction and royal decrees outlawing certain kinds of magic, set in place in order to maintain some kind of social control.

In Korantia, sorcery – essentially defined as the practice of any magic that does not come as a gift from the Gods - is illegal in the majority of cities. In the Taskan Empire, magic that could rival or challenge the Emperor's unique power and status is treasonous – any kind of immortality magic being top of the list. And there are always prohibitions against accomplishing things with magic that would be illegal to do by mundane means. Murderers, thieves and swindlers are the same whether they accomplish their crimes by brute force, trickery or magic.

The Limits of Humanity

One of the reasons magic is deployed is to meet personal human ambitions. Acquiring 'power' always needs to be qualified by what someone hopes to do with the power they acquire, not an undefined ends in its own right. To gain riches, to control and influence others. But also to become stronger, faster, smarter, able to cheat death, or perhaps to access worlds and states of being not usually accessible to humans. These things are reach beyond the capability of a human frame and human mind – magic provides a way. But in doing so there is some sense perhaps of a transgression – entering into an existence that human beings were not intended to experience, or that stretching the limits of the possible in one regard might diminish one's humanity in another. Hence where magic becomes powerful and permanent and directly impacts on the humanity of its user, there can be a price to pay – whether that is physical, psychological or spiritual.

Everyone Matters

The setting never tries to differentiate how rules are applied to player characters compared to other people in the setting – except in one respect, which is Luck Points, the essential – and limited - plot armour of the player character which is an optional device. Underling and Rabble rules belie the idea that every NPC has, in principle, an inner life, a set of beliefs, passions and desires to cling to life unless they have a clear motivation or directive not to. This isn't intended to be a burden in play, and the Underling or Rabble rules, perhaps better expressed as quick resolution mechanics, can be a useful GM device in managing a lot of participants. But it is perhaps something for GMs and players to take into account when figuring out how setting NPCs will respond and react to their PCs' actions. And that there is no such thing as a homogenous crowd of foes, supporters or bystanders, however much it may look that way.

Setting Stories

No matter what the PCs do there are always wheels in motion as major historical processes, personal dramas and political games play out in the world around them. Player characters may get squashed by one of these wheels, harness it to their own purposes or try to stick a spanner in the works and bring a major plot line screeching to a halt. These reflect ways in which the world is moving, historical trajectories that may have begun generations ago and are still relevant, or current conflicts that promise new beginnings and change the future.

The Restoration of Korantia

- Korantia in danger of being devoured piecemeal by the mighty Taskan Empire if it cannot unite.
- The Jekkarene theocracy, and an ancient enemy once more threatens as it rises to new height with Taskan support
- A young vigorous Emperor, Koibos, brings hope to many but wields little actual power to bring the Korantine city states together under his rule. Nevertheless he nurtures ambitions to restore the empire his ancestors once ruled.
- A rival power structure, the federal assembly of Korantine city-states held on the Isle of Valos, provides a swell of politics that will ultimately frustrate the Emperor at every turn.
- Militaristic warrior cults dedicated to Lanis, the Sun God, cheerlead for the Emperor in many Korantine lands...
- ...But republican spirit is strong in many of the most powerful Korantine city-states, whether they embrace democratic or oligarchic regimes
- And at Kipsipsindra a dual monarchy has no need or desire to look up to a distant Emperor
- Zarendra, a far flung colony across the Ocean recently rediscovered that is

entirely dedicated to the Sun God and proclaims loyalty to the Emperor

- The Jekkarenes, enemies of the Korantines for centuries, are now the Taskans' closest allies, a dagger aimed at the underside of Korantia. They once called upon the Ocean to drown Korantis; if Korantia should rise again, will they produce another cataclysm?

The Apotheosis of the Taskan Emperor, Zygas Taga

The immortal Zygas Taga works towards the moment he can quit his mortal form and take his place among the greater gods

- Zygas Taga's apotheosis depends on the worship demanded of every Taskan citizen. His counsellors advise another 250,000 converts are required to assure his smooth transition to an exalted place among the gods
- Wracked with pain, his physical shape is warped and twisted, unable to contain the supernatural energy coursing through his veins – and so unseen in public for more than a generation
- His Viceroy and factotum, the Iron Simulacrum, a magical iron statue animated with a fragment of the Emperor's mighty spirit, is tasked with ensuring nothing stands in the way of his master's ascent to sit amongst the gods...
- ...but fears extinction when the Emperor's final apotheosis happens and seeks a way to persist when the Emperor is gone.
- Maresh Martek, ruler of the Empire's capital, Taskay, intends his city shall become the true heart of Empire when the Emperor ascends, and there will be no place for the monstrous Simulacrum.
- Many believe that somewhere in the decadent, declining city of Sorandib lies the secret to the Emperor's immortality and the Simulacrum's existence. Sure enough, in that place is an magical device

called the Similarity Engine, which can be harnessed to power the most demanding, world-changing enchantments.

The New Korazoon Movement

The ancient ways of the desert are changing as animist spirit warriors of the New Korazoon Movement inspired by the shaman Haljaf strike out into neighbouring lands

- Their ambition: to amass sufficient power to awaken the spirit of the Korazoon, and restore their homeland to what it was centuries ago – a fertile basin with rich pastures, flowing water and wealthy cities.
- These Soribisi nomadic tribesmen and the city-dwellers who give their support, willingly or not, are still few in number, but have managed to secure one of the Sultanates of Djesmirket, and with the city of Ankwar as their new capital can grow their power and resources
- Meanwhile the exiled sultan and his family bide their time and attempt to gather allies to help them retake their city.
- Will they get help from the jealous, squabbling royalty of the other sultanates of Djesmirket?



- Or will they seek allies further afield, in their weakened state doomed to make compacts with potentially malevolent powers, from the Taskans in the North to the much more malevolent Sultan of Jelhai?
- ...Or could they somehow marshal magical forces to confront the spirits and demons at the command of Haljaf and his followers?

The Oceans Rising

Across the Inner Ocean lies adventure and opportunity – the chance to carve out a kingdom, name a new settlement, or stumble upon untold riches. The bones of countless ambitious explorers freebooters, settlers and explorers litter the ocean bed.

- Korantine traders from many cities still ply the Northern sea lanes, but increasingly Kipsipsindra's navy rules the waves in these parts...
- Taskans have made their first steps onto the Inner Ocean from naval bases provided by their Jekkarene allies
- Jekkarenes explore the Ocean islands in search of ancient magic that once gave their moon-queen mastery of the tides and sank Old Korantis
- The treacherous Arko of Solarne, governor of the Isle of Tempigone for the Korantine city of Himela, plots to make himself ruler of the central sea lanes with the help of a pirate coalition and the Orcish settlement on Fierla
- The immense merchant ships of Sharranket are the untouchable masters of the ocean waves all across the South, hauling priceless cargoes back to hungry markets around the Gulf of Eilak and beyond.
- The merchant princes who sail these galleys become players in the local affairs in every land they reach. Trading posts



become strategic nodes in a worldwide network.

- The Sea Peoples of the Inner Ocean consider the islands and sea lanes their domain. They lack the technology of the huge Sharranketan ships but they have the gods of wind and wave and the dark briny deep on their side...
- But the Sea Peoples routinely fight amongst themselves, and some seek allies with foreign intruders to give them an advantage.
- Orcs from Kasperan long ago learned to sail upon the Ocean, and while they mostly keep to the shores along of their homeland, some by accident or design established themselves in the wild lands of Fierla.
- Flimsy reed galleys launched from the shores of Uxmal have been spotted at sea for the first time anyone can remember – powered by crews of undead oarsmen. Unknown to the outside world, the terrifying cannibals of Uxmal are intent on rediscovering an ancestral home that lies somewhere on a land mass in or around the Inner Ocean.

Setting Inspirations

I have been fascinated by the ancient world since I was 11. That's now a very long time ago. That fascination drove what I studied at school, at undergraduate and postgraduate level, stayed with me ever since. I still keep a growing

collection of books on all sorts of ancient history topics, although these days the Latin and Greek is more than a little rusty. So no surprise that the primary real-world inspirations for the world of Thennla are drawn from antiquity, and in particular the Mediterranean region including the Middle East.

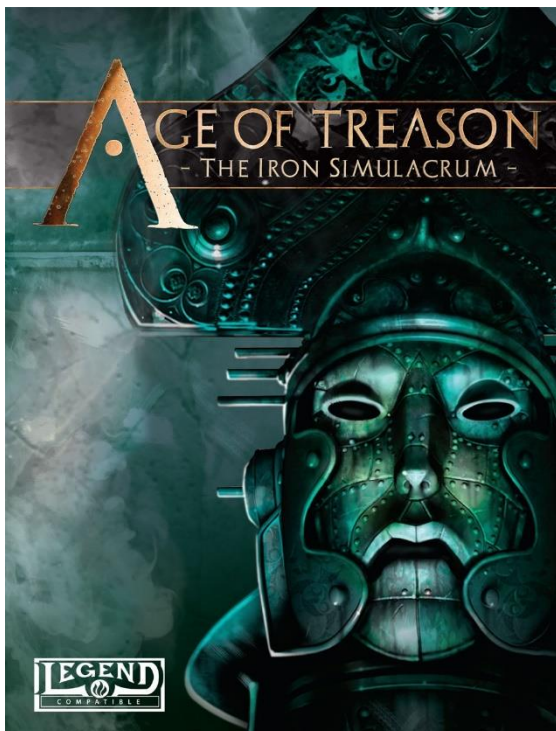
The setting plays fast and loose with taking inspiration from roughly the same geographical space in different eras of antiquity and lining them up alongside each other as contemporaries. So Korantia, which is largely Classical-Hellenistic (say 500-200BCE) in character, sits alongside the Taskan Empire which is more Eastern-Roman Empire-Byzantine (roughly 300-600CE) inspired, but also some of the neighbouring Thennalt people are modelled on Early Iron Age and Archaic Greece (Circa 800-500BCE) and across the sea are people with many touchstones among cultures in the Late Bronze Age and Early Iron Age Aegean (1200-800BCE). The ancient cultures used for inspiration are less direct analogues than examples to think with about how cultures should be organised, what their pressure points and concerns will be and sometimes to visualise. History isn't a science, and many of the takeouts from studying ancient history applied in creating the inhabitants of Thennla are very much my take on things. And entirely alien elements will get thrown in and mixed in the pot.

I guess it's worth adding that there's not a great deal of inspiration from fantasy literature going on. I don't really read any – apart from the obligatory teenage Tolkien obsession, and a spell of Conan comic books, it's never been a big draw for me. Arabian Nights aside – that's a shameless and obvious influence on how Assabia has been shaped in recent years – fantasy influences have mostly come from gaming. Glorantha, as a long time Runequest player, of course. At least it's earlier, joyfully different and still not yet overwritten version, not the quagmire of bloated lore that seems to excite today's gloranthaphiles. But I hope that

what Thennla does show is a dash of that creativity and high magic, mashed up with a bit of Young Kingdoms cynicism - and some Hyborean Age grit mixed in with its ancient world genes.

Thennla as a Published Setting

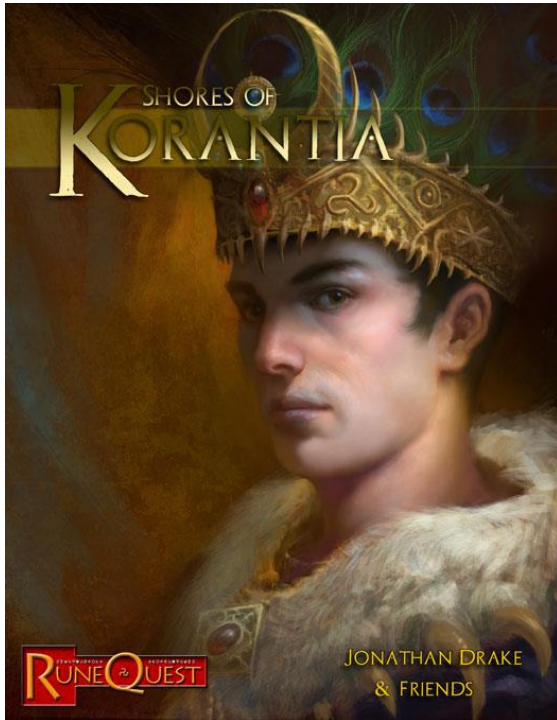
The world that is now called Thennla evolved more-or-less organically over a couple of decades of play in the 80s and 90s, most of the time using the Runequest 3rd Edition rule set. But I only it only really had a clear framework applied to it from 2009 when I was bringing the mass of hand-written and half-typed material together to try to publish as a setting book for Runequest. Mongoose publishing had the Runequest licence at the time and I'd approached its principal, Matt Sprange, about trying out my setting as a published work. To which Matt agreed so long as, while Mongoose were going to take the chance to print and sell, the origination costs were all mine. So I needed to buy in the artwork and the layout, and basically take responsibility for a lot of things I



had no experience of doing. Admission: I had managed a publishing unit before as part of a previous job, but had no hands-on experience of actually doing any of the key tasks involved publishing myself. My colleague Steve Maher did the fabulous cover art as a favour; and introduced me to his friend Mark Stacey, a seasoned illustrator of Osprey Publishing military titles, among other things, who produced the interior illustrations.

But... I was quickly faced with converting everything I was writing to Mongoose's new Runequest edition. This was, frankly, a serious chore - Mongoose Runequest (sometimes MRQ1) was unfamiliar to me and the more I dug in the more I discovered it to be in every way less good (as generous a way of saying it as I can manage) than all the editions that went before. But by the time the work was only part done Mongoose had produced a new Runequest rules set, commonly known as Mongoose Runequest 2 (MRQ2) by Lawrence Whitaker and Pete Nash, which was an enormous improvement. Immediately the task of adapting the setting to the dame rules became easier. A pleasure, even. The new rules provided a framework that had elegance, but also really malleable, and while I tinkered with the rules to get what I wanted for the setting, they were immensely forgiving and proved a really solid base to work from. Even so, by the time we went to print in 2011, Mongoose had lost the Runequest licence. And so *Age of Treason: The Iron Simulacrum*, the first book to be published for the Thennla setting, went to market under Legend, the new brand with which Mongoose rebadged its former Runequest line. A companion book followed which provided some expansion on the Taskan Empire, provided information on some of the people living on its frontiers and introduced the city of Sorandib – which remains for me perhaps the pivot point and heart of many of the setting's adventures.

At this point Pete and Lawrence picked up the Runequest licence as The Design Mechanism and took their work on the game system to the



next level with Runequest 6. They gave me the opportunity to reboot the setting with TDM as the publishers and I jumped at the chance. With the new book, *Shores of Korantia*. I could finally publish a work with the Runequest brand attached. A boyhood ambition ticked off. More than that it was a much more satisfying experience thanks to a great deal more support and advice from the publishers than ever happened under Mongoose. And who took care of all the actual publishing part of the process. I still offer my apologies to Colin Driver, the cartographer, who had to wrestle with my hand drawn maps and even those created for *Age of Treason* in which the scales were, it turned out, totally broken... More positively, the Ship rules I had written into *Shores of Korantia* were picked up by Lawrence and Pete as the basis for a generic set of sailing rules published in *Ships and Shieldwalls* alongside their mass combat rules, and it was great to have their stamp of approval in that way.

While some of the *Age of Treason* content was revised and repackaged for the *Taskan Empire* supplement, more material from the Iron Companion came out as the *Sorandib* supplement. By this time I was delighted that

others had taken enough interest in the setting to do some of the heavy lifting on turning out new work. I'd read Bruce Turner's play reports of his *Cedar in Ashes* campaign, and it was really exciting to see how someone had taken a setting I created and made it their own, taken it in new directions and made new stuff up. The flavour and gaming style that came shining through the reports was one I really liked. So it was fantastic news that Bruce would pen two scenario books for Thennla (*The Arakuline Tribute* and *Khakun Shrugs*, both 2017). I'm sorry his plans to write a book on the Jekkarene theocracy with input from Lawrence Whitaker didn't come to anything as energies fizzled out and I myself was too tied up with day job to make any real contribution.

And that's where the story ends for now - but I hope that the setting will see new works in print one day. The Assabian Rites articles published over the last year or so are a tentative step in that direction, and at the same time I've been running a game set in Djesmirket with some of the old friends who started the journey with me 40 years ago in the region now known as Korantia. So who knows. Maybe the long talked about Assabian Rites book will eventually see the light of day!

